

Player to watch **TRAVIS HEAD**

The left-handed opener has been a key figure for Australia at the top of the order over the past 24 months. He has consistently looked to take the attack to the bowlers, defying conditions with his aggressive approach from the outset. His return to fitness during the 2023 World Cup proved pivotal, revitalising Australia's campaign and culminating in his match-winning 137 against India in the final.

While Head has, at times, appeared vulnerable to the short ball, his ability to counterattack remains a defining trait. With Australia placed in Group B alongside Afghanistan, England, and South Africa — all boasting pace attacks capable of exploiting this weakness — his battles against high-quality fast bowling promise to be enthralling.

Adding to the intrigue is Australia's round-robin fixture in Rawalpindi, a venue that, not long ago, produced a record-breaking 1,768 runs in a single Test match between England and Pakistan. Given the potential for a high-scoring encounter, Head will relish the opportunity to capitalise on favourable batting conditions.



K. R. DEEPAK

Todd Murphy, Matt Kuhnemann, and Mitchell Swepson have talent but lack significant ODI experience, making their inclusion a calculated risk. In conditions where spin could play a pivotal role, will the Aussies back one of their young spinners or rely on part-time options such as Glenn Maxwell to supplement Adam Zampa? Either way, the lack of a seasoned second spinner is a glaring issue.

A broader problem facing several teams, including Australia, is the lack of ODI cricket leading into this tournament. Since lifting the World Cup trophy in India in November 2023, Australia has played only 12 ODIs.

It will play a two-match ODI series in Sri Lanka, where Sean Abbott and Cooper Connolly, along with domestic

stars Jake Fraser-McGurk, Ben Dwarshuis, Spencer Johnson, and Sangha, have been added to the squad. Sangha could be a reserve player in Pakistan, as he was for the ODI World Cup in India in 2023.

Meanwhile, Steve Smith appears set to take captaincy. This overhaul is perhaps the most significant talking point. Apart from Cummins and Hazlewood, Australia has also lost all-rounder Mitch Marsh, who was ruled out in late January due to a back injury. Adding to the upheaval, Marcus Stoinis retired from the format in early February, removing a seasoned all-round option from the mix.

The batting order will also look different. David Warner has retired, while Cameron Green is unavailable

following a back surgery. These absences mean Australia will need to find new solutions at the top of the order and in the middle overs, areas that were previously anchored by experienced campaigners.

SQUAD

Alex Carey, Nathan Ellis, Aaron Hardie, Travis Head, Josh Inglis, Marnus Labuschagne, Glenn Maxwell, Matt Short, Steve Smith, Mitchell Starc, Adam Zampa. [Four players to be added]